

2056 — And Not a Day Sooner

A book, chapter by chapter.

Chapter 1: The Order of Things

2056 — what's special about then? Only that it's thirty years away. And the significance of that is, what? The significance is that here in New Zealand, everything governments signal as necessary, that they would fix "if only you would vote for us" even with coalition support generally don't get started within the three year term and really only show their problems years later — more typically thirty. Infrastructure projects take up to twenty-five years to get from decision to completion, and at least several decades after that before we see the benefits that motivated the change. This is the "thirty-year cycle" that exists but is largely overlooked in our planning. (The Infrastructure Commission does operate on a 30-year planning brief — but as we'll see, without sufficient authority to protect that horizon.)

This is a book about scheduling, forward planning, anticipating types of contingency and the need to avoid unwarranted political interference in projects. We can improve our performance at these measures with some changes to our governance, none of which would upset our legislative freedoms, though all would require some public pressure to overcome the "turf-protecting" instincts of both the two major and all the larger minor parties.

These topics are about our unavoidable, long-term, best-case scenarios, sector by sector. The tragedy is that we have already lost so much momentum that our best-case scenarios aren't all that good — but at least we should avoid making them worse.

I'm a practical person. So are we all, all Kiwis, pretty much. And most of us do a bit of DIY. We know to get the boxing firm and only then mix the concrete. You know that. I know that. Why does it seem so often, that once our guys get into parliament they lose sight of it? Things have a natural sequence. Lose that and you're done.

I have a theory — about why this seems to happen. Why things get attempted out of the necessary sequence. Attempted and sometimes completed but rarely as was required, costed, or scheduled, rarely taking account of all the essential requirements. Out of order actually.

Here are some reasons: delay; vested interests; and optimistic thinking, for starters:

Delay: The harbour bridge was proposed in 1881 and built about seventy years later, by which time such population pressure had built up that almost immediately (in infrastructure terms) its capacity had to be doubled.

Vested interests: (not necessarily corruption) Why was Auckland's vast, expensive and severely overloaded motorway network chosen over the rail links that are now — far too late — recognised as being the better option? Passenger trains, trams, and light rail are incredibly effective at moving people but in 1955 all the city engineers knew a great deal about roading, but nothing about rail, and like all people who are paid until they are not needed, naturally made the case and made it well, that road was the way to go.

Optimistic thinking: Our politicians have matured in a system that rewards action rather than result. There is much back slapping over the start of building the new medical school — as if that already

solved the doctor shortage. Actually, when the school is completed the shortage of GPs will continue to get worse, as a little *realistic* thought will reveal. More on that later.

Based on even these, we can see that despite the differences between this sample of causes, there is an underlying similarity. Not the old (but valid) wise saw: "Beware the unforeseen consequences". No, the problems all arise from failing to quantify the foreseen consequences, failing to do the "armchair philosophy"; which is worthwhile because, though it's not generally acknowledged, much innovative detail comes to mind, not while scribbling at the desk, but while listening to music, or fishing, or sitting under an apple tree. Then it is written down at the desk and few readers will understand the amount of preliminary cogitation required.

It's a good exercise, too, to think about all the likely outcomes of a course of action, and then, as well, the likely outcomes if the opposite were done. And in various combinations. Those who have worked in government organisations may have experienced support for spending productive time 'musing', but typically that would be rare.

One of the "foreseen consequences" is that nothing is perfect. In any activity problems are inevitable. Rain halts play. Deliveries arrive late. Staff get sick. We know how to deal with this. When timing a project, it is usual to allow for a contingency of some percentage, often about ten percent, being added to the cost and schedule, hopefully to arrive at a realistic rather than merely theoretical proposal. But it's rarely enough.

The very worst foreseen consequence (because it never fails to occur and is usually severe), is for projects to be canned, or their specifications changed, or funding withheld. Hundreds of millions spent in planning and the project cancelled on change of government (for instance: Auckland Light Rail, January 2024; Biometric Capability Update, June 2026).

This problem of 'canned projects' depends on our being fed ambit claims about projects. We too readily accept the publicity (with change of government) that a planned infrastructure creation is merely a vanity project of the predecessors, that the projected costs are continually increasing and that the completion date regularly being moved further out; and so the only sensible course of action (they claim) is to cancel it and assign the funds to something 'more useful'. The unfortunate truth is that in our current environment such cost increases cannot be avoided, because inflation regularly increases the price, more so every time there is a delay, often the consequence of the re-planning required to meet a politically motivated change of scope.

But, ambit claims are hard to refute when the decisions are huge and complex, as of course they are. Should our ferries carry trains, Yes or No? Should the spine of our inter-city bulk transport be road, or should it be rail, or even coastal shipping? Which choice affects which other? How does having a friend with a trucking business affect the decision? Should we, as a nation, blindly accept the choices of a few in caucus, or if not, how should these matters be handled, and by whom?

How does this regular twitching of projects and priorities affect the contracts for our infrastructure? The firms who tender are well aware of the political uncertainty. Their prices reflect this, because it affects the costs; and the uncertainty leads to such severe penalty payments as we now see being levied on a government that shuts down the work before it reaches its proper conclusion.

In the face of such expense and disruption, why do our elected representatives shut down, delay, or rejig requirements and budgets in so apparently careless a manner?

It's tempting to put this down to mere political point scoring, but the more probable driver is the fear

of political non-survival. However, that fear is hardly realistic because change doesn't put all the elected representatives out of jobs, it merely reduces (most of) them to the opposition. Furthermore, parties in New Zealand generally hold power for several election cycles. Despite that, it seems there is still a need to savage the opponents' projects.

It's a nonsense of course. By the time a long-term project runs to completion and implementation, it is far too late for its proponents to become entrenched in power by riding on the back of its success. Everyone overlooks the thirty-year cycle between concept and the realisation of social benefits.

It bears repeating that nothing is perfect. But the record is clear: our infrastructure projects, if completed with careful oversight but without delay, without regular modification and without political disruption, would have been delivered faster, cheaper, and perhaps better — regardless of which philosophy initiated them.

It's fair to ask: what sort of projects, which aspects of our lives, does this sort of conflict affect? Unfortunately all are affected. If government money goes into something, few elements of that expenditure are safe. Those that are? They are the ones that a government would touch at its peril. ACC—would we sit still for unhelpful changes to that, our accident insurer? Reserve Bank—we all trust that to keep our mortgages manageable. What government would risk our wrath if they attempt to gag it? Judiciary, Electoral Commission, Auditor General, Ombudsman, Parliamentary Commissioner; all are historically sacrosanct here, but even the Super Fund, though nominally insulated from party politics, is not entirely protected; it's currently serving as a political football.

So, what can be done to prevent tampering with the long-term, major, culturally and economically critical projects that we so desperately need to bring this country out of its low point on the international totem pole?

We need methods that will ensure our major projects are appropriate; are addressed in the right sequence; and are properly costed, funded, awarded, monitored, controlled; and guarded against disruption.

The Infrastructure Commission should be given real teeth. Its procedures and research provide considerable confidence in its findings. Coincidentally, its planning horizon is thirty years, but for different reasons than we investigate here; for example, the Commission's analysis takes account of weather events on workforce projects — my analysis does not. It is hard to fault the Commission's reasoning, including its identification of what makes the efficient projects stand out. Look there for identification of the more useful projects than can be afforded now. Which works need longer planning and why. All our infrastructure needs, priorities, strategies, sequences, costs and funding. The discussions are clearly evidence based rather than the broad-brush political claims.

The Commission's recommendations should be made binding upon the government. Of course a statutory, unelected body should never have unfettered power, so there should be provision for government to overturn or modify a recommendation, subject to its providing a reasoned explanation for rejection. Such rejection ought to be contestable, however, and provision would need be made for a final ruling, perhaps by a Select Committee, a Citizens Council or the Supreme Court.

Regardless of the means, much more discipline must be applied to the orderly planning, construction and maintenance of the facilities that support our quality of life. Money alone is not the answer — those making the decisions have to take proper account of changes in population pressure

and in how modifying the environment alters people's behaviour; by now government ministers would surely have forgotten the lesson of the Harbour Bridge; too small almost from the day it opened, as families rushed to build in the newly accessible suburbs. As it turned out, the expensive bridge didn't have the expected fifty-year, adequate life — it didn't even have ten. Now that the "fifty years" are behind us, an additional crossing is finally being considered, but too late, and at the present rate of such matters it will arrive too late, have been too costly, and may all too soon become too small. This new crossing discussion should have been in progress fifty years after the clip-ons, at least by 2005, and by now construction would be underway.

It takes thirty years for major infrastructure projects, if successful, to solve a social problem. At best, about twenty years for the problem to be accepted, plans made and the building completed, and a further ten for the social change to get bedded in.

However, infrastructure is only part of the story. Outside of infrastructure, there are social, governance and financial issues that require our attention both to support and enable the infrastructure programmes, and for the social benefits they confer. For while the bricks and mortar are crucially important, life in New Zealand is also radically affected by wage equity, governance, and monopoly controls, for example. Such low-cost, high-impact matters as these, can be legislated, implemented and effective almost immediately.

But for the big things, plan now for 2056. The following chapters explain why.

Chapter 2 (Housing) coming soon.

Peter L Collins © 2026